

14,109. These are good numbers, but I was honestly expecting a bit more, specifically keeping the Vivo X300 in mind, which scored better in benchmarks.

CAMERA

The Vivo X300 FE is a camera-first smartphone, and the hardware reflects that. You get a triple-camera setup led by a 50MP primary sensor (Sony IMX921, 1/1.56", f/1.57) with OIS, paired with a 50MP telephoto camera (Sony IMX882) offering optical zoom and extended reach, and an 8MP ultra-wide lens with a 115-degree field of view. On the front, there's a 50MP selfie camera. On paper, this is a versatile system, covering everything from standard shots to portraits and long-range zoom, with the added backing of ZEISS optics and Vivo's image processing stack.

Vivo leans heavily on its ZEISS partnership here, not just for optics but also for tuning. Features like ZEISS multifocal portrait modes (ranging from 23mm to 100mm), multiple bokeh styles inspired by ZEISS lenses and the AI True Clarity Engine aim to deliver more natural textures, better subject separation, and improved detail retention, especially at higher zoom levels. There's also support for a detachable telephoto extender, which pushes focal length further for niche use cases like distant landscapes or architectural shots.

In real-world use, the main camera does most of the heavy lifting, and it does it well. Images come out sharp, with strong dynamic range and good detail retention. Colours, for the most part, look vibrant, although there are instances where they lean slightly towards oversaturation rather than strict accuracy. Low-light performance is another strong area, with the sensor managing to pull in enough light while keeping noise under control.

The telephoto lens is a reliable performer. It maintains consistent colour profile with the main sensor, which helps when switching between lenses. Detail levels are good, and importantly, it holds up well even in low light, some-



thing that's often a weak point in this segment. For portraits, the telephoto lens actually delivers better results than the dedicated portrait mode in many cases, offering more natural separation and sharper subject detail.

The ultra-wide camera is where the setup feels less convincing. There is a noticeable drop in quality when you switch to it, both in terms of detail and dynamic range. It is usable, but it doesn't quite match the standard set by the primary and telephoto cameras.

Zoom is a mixed bag. Up to around 3x, results are solid and usable. Beyond that, especially with digital zoom, the processing becomes aggressive. Images tend to lose detail and can appear overly softened, sometimes taking on an almost 'oil painting' look. The optional telephoto extender does help push boundaries, but it's clearly more of a niche accessory than something most users will rely on daily, especially if they are buying an 'FE.'

Tools like AI Retouch, object removal, reflection erase and even audio noise reduction for videos are designed to enhance usability. These work well in controlled scenarios, though, like most AI features, results vary.

VERDICT

The Vivo X300 FE is a good smartphone, but it feels slightly caught between its intent and where it sits in the lineup. Vivo has delivered a well-rounded package. You get a compact, premium

design, an excellent colour-accurate display, strong battery life, and a camera system that performs reliably.

The bigger conversation is around its positioning. At this price, it sits very close to the Vivo X300, which, with ongoing offers, starts to feel like the more complete option, thanks to its better camera and performance, while offering a similar overall experience.

This simply makes me wonder if using the MediaTek Dimensity 9500s or another chipset in that range would have allowed for a better balance, or if Vivo is intentionally placing it this way to make space for the Vivo X300T, if and when that arrives or maybe to show X300 as a promising choice.

For what it's worth, the Vivo X300 FE is a solid compact flagship, one that makes sense more for what it offers than where it is placed.

—Ashish Singh

SPECIFICATIONS

Chipset: Qualcomm Snapdragon 8 Gen 5 Mobile Platform | RAM: 12 GB | Storage: 256 GB | Display: 6.31-inch FHD+ AMOLED | Refresh rate: 120Hz | Brightness: 5000 nits | Camera (rear): 50 MP + 50 MP + 8 MP | Camera (Front): 20 MP | Battery: 6,500 mAh | Charging: 90W

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